

Mexican Hot Chocolate Brownies

1 cup (2 sticks/226g) unsalted butter, melted, plus more for greasing
1 cup (220g) firmly packed light brown sugar
1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
3 large eggs, room temperature
1 tablespoon instant espresso powder (optional)
1 tablespoon vanilla extract
1 tablespoon ground cinnamon
1 teaspoon salt
½ teaspoon cayenne pepper
1 cup (120g) all-purpose flour
¾ cup (75g) unsweetened cocoa powder
1½ cups (260g) dark or semisweet chocolate chips, plus more for sprinkling
Large marshmallows, halved (optional)

While these might be incredibly simple to make, they do not compromise on what makes a brownie a brownie: they're fudgy, almost molten, as though flour were merely whispered at the recipe—almost like taking a sip of the best hot chocolate. Growing up, hot chocolate for me meant Mexican hot chocolate, which included spices like cayenne and cinnamon. Here they offer just a kiss of subtle heat, but the effect keeps the brownies from tasting one-note. And if you really want to embrace the hot chocolate experience, you could top these with brûléed or toasted marshmallows. **MAKES 9 BROWNIES**

Preheat the oven to 350°F. Lightly coat an 8-inch square baking pan with butter and fully line the pan with parchment paper (see page 33). Set aside.

In a large bowl, combine the butter, brown sugar, granulated sugar, eggs, espresso powder (if using), vanilla, cinnamon, salt, and cayenne. Whisk until smooth and well combined. Add the flour and cocoa powder and use a spatula to stir until just a few dry streaks remain. Add the chocolate chips and stir until the flour is fully incorporated.

Spread the batter into the prepared pan. Sprinkle with about ¼ cup more chocolate chips, if desired. Bake for 30 minutes, until fudgy or 40 minutes, until set in the middle.

Let the brownies cool completely in the pan before slicing into 9 squares. If desired, top each slice with a marshmallow half and toast using a kitchen torch or place under the broiler for 1 to 2 minutes until golden brown.

The brownies can be covered with foil or plastic wrap and stored at room temperature for up to 1 week. They can also be sliced, wrapped in plastic wrap, and frozen in a freezer-safe container for up to 3 months. Defrost at room temperature.

Variations

FOR AN EXTRA-RICH CHOCOLATE FLAVOR, use Dutch-process cocoa powder.

FOR A CLASSIC BROWNIE, omit the cinnamon and cayenne pepper.



super easy flavor combinations

CARAMEL BROWNIES: Spread half of the brownie batter into the pan. Unwrap 1 (11-ounce) bag of chewy caramel candies and arrange them in a single layer on top of the batter. Dollop the remaining batter on top. Bake as directed plus an additional 5 minutes.

PEPPERMINT BROWNIES: Replace the chocolate chips with an equal measure of chopped peppermint bark or chocolate-peppermint candies such as Andes chocolate mints or York Peppermint Patties. Bake as directed.

PEANUT BUTTER BROWNIES: Dollop the top of the unbaked brownies with ½ cup of creamy peanut butter and swirl into the batter with the tip of a knife. Bake as directed plus an additional 5 minutes.